

BEYOND THE SCORE

Case 2 · Riley Family

Pākehā intergenerational household, Palmerston North: flood cover withdrawn by a climate map, an overdraft denied by a data profile, in the same week.

THE HOUSEHOLD

Callum Riley 18 · engineering student, the one the system addressed
| *"It's not that I don't want help. I just don't want help that's keeping tabs on me."*

Callum is in his first year of engineering at Massey, working casual fast-food shifts and freelancing digital artwork online. He lives with his mother and grandfather in the ageing home his grandfather once owned outright, remortgaged after a redundancy and a divorce reshaped the household. He sees himself as practical and digitally savvy, compartmentalises stress, and lets anxiety surface as sarcasm or silence rather than discussion. This week an automated system denied him a \$300 overdraft he prequalified for on paper — and he suspects the open banking consent he ticked during the application.

Melanie Riley 47 · school administrator, seasonal surveyor
| *"They keep telling us to plan for the future — but with what? Another app? Another form? Another loan?"*

Melanie works thirty hours a week in a school office and picks up survey contracts in the holidays. After her divorce a decade ago she moved back into her childhood home to support her father and raise Callum, and she takes pride in holding things together — financially, emotionally, logistically. She manages the accounts tightly, cycles through credit cards, trusts her own bank out of long loyalty and distrusts anything automated. This week the insurer wrote to say the house is no longer eligible for flood cover.

Graham Riley 74 · retired builder, former Territorial Army officer
| *"They told us to build. So we did. Now they say we should have known better?"*

Graham bought the house in the early 1980s and paid it off over two decades; after his wife died and his daughter's marriage ended, it became a shared refuge. His routines — early walks, the lawns, the paper, midday tea — hold his sense of order. He does not use online services, values face-to-face for anything that matters, and cannot see how a risk map drawn from data he has never been shown can decide whether the home he built high is insurable.

THE SCENE

SIMULATION 2 · "Weathering Out"

A damp Saturday afternoon in Palmerston North. The household is subdued after Melanie opens a letter discontinuing their flood insurance. Earlier that week, Callum was unexpectedly denied a student overdraft despite prequalifying on paper; he suspects the open banking consent he agreed to during an online application. The conversation unfolds in the living room as rain taps against the old windowpanes.

MELANIE (*reads aloud from the letter*) “They regret to inform us that due to updated climate zoning, coverage is no longer available. Effective immediately.” Just like that — 40 years of payments, and we’re too risky now?

GRAHAM (*sitting still, arms crossed*) They can take their map and shove it. I built this house high for a reason. We’ve never had water inside.

CALLUM (*quietly*) They’re not saying it’s about what’s happened. It’s what might happen. That’s how the system works now.

MELANIE So what? We just live in fear of the next forecast? What happens if the river floods next month and we’ve got no cover?

GRAHAM You do what we always did — fix it yourself. That’s what insurance was for: a backup. Now they act like we owe them for the risk of existing.

CALLUM I kind of get where they’re coming from. But... it still feels wrong. I got pinged this week too. Tried to get an overdraft from the bank — like, \$300. They said I didn’t meet the profile.

MELANIE You what? But you’ve got a job! And uni costs are expected.

CALLUM Yeah, but they’re using some kind of predictive thing. Open banking. I ticked the box during the app. Didn’t really think much of it.

GRAHAM That’s the problem. You kids click things before you know what they mean.

CALLUM It’s not like they explained it. It was built in. “Tick here to streamline your application.” Now I’m apparently too ‘unstable’ to borrow three hundred bucks.

MELANIE (*sits down heavily*) So we’re too risky to insure, and you’re too risky to lend to. Even though we’re doing everything right?

CALLUM That’s what gets me. It’s not even about what I’ve done — it’s about the data. The pattern. Like... we’re just numbers in a spreadsheet that keeps shifting.

GRAHAM That’s not banking. That’s bloody profiling.

MELANIE (*exhales*) I never thought I’d miss the days when you could just call your branch manager and explain. At least there was a person on the other end.

CALLUM I don’t even know who my “bank” is anymore. The app is the whole thing. No one talks to you unless something’s wrong.

GRAHAM You know what’s wrong? They moved the goalposts. We built. We paid. We stayed out of trouble. And now we’re “uncovered” and you’re “unapproved.”

MELANIE It’s not just about us. I see it at school too. Families juggling apps, credit cards, rent increases — and the language in these letters gets more robotic by the year. “We regret.” “As per our model.”

CALLUM (*small laugh*) Even the chatbot told me it was “sorry” for the inconvenience.

GRAHAM Sorry doesn’t fix a flooded home. Or get you three hundred bucks. Or give you back 40 years of loyalty.

MELANIE (*quiet*) I think what hurts is — this place used to feel safe. The house. The bank. Even the weather. Now it’s like they all turned their backs at once.

CALLUM What do we do?

GRAHAM Keep the gutters clear. Keep our heads down. That’s all I’ve ever done.

MELANIE Maybe we also start asking harder questions. Not just fixing things ourselves, but pushing back. There has to be another way.

CALLUM Maybe. But right now, I just want to find a way to feel less like a data point and more like a person.

[Scene ends. Graham returns to his chair. Melanie folds the letter into a drawer with others she has not had the energy to deal with. Callum pulls out his phone, stares at the banking app icon, and presses “log out.”]

WHAT MOVED

The household was re-scored twice in one week — uninsurable on a climate map, unlendable on a data profile — without anyone's behaviour changing. Three answers sat at one table: fix it yourself, push back, log out. The letter went into the drawer with the others.

ABOUT THIS CASE

The people and events in this case are corpus-constrained composites: relational models built from documented Aotearoa New Zealand research, not portraits of any household, whānau, kāiga or community. The arc is an anticipatory scenario — a structured hypothesis built to be tested, not a record of events.

Full case position, corpus anchors, references, and log: BTS_Case2_Trace.